

RANJAN RAHI

tor, Dadiji Farmtech and SBPJ Foods are setting up base in Vaishali, while Pramod Laddu (Pramod Confectionery & Food Products) and Sona Biscuit are establishing units in Patna. "These are part of 40 investment proposals worth approximately Rs 10,798 crore that are at various stages of approval. Nineteen of these proposals have already been allotted land and, for the others, land is being identified," says Nitish Mishra. Optimism is keeping pace: according to the Chief Minister's Office, the investments will create 40,000 new jobs across the state.

As much as the immediate payoffs, all that velocity has also ignited hopes for a new era of industrialisation—the idea that Bihar has indeed turned a corner. The contrast is with a history that's all-too-familiar. Bihar could justly be thought

THE TURNAROUND

- **Some 40 proposals, worth Rs 10,798 crore, are at various stages of approval**
- **Ambuja Concrete North is setting up a Rs 1,600-cr. unit in Nawada; Coca-Cola a Rs 1,235-cr. plant in Buxar; Pepsi adding a second bottling unit after a new one in Begusarai**
- **Textile, leather boom areas**

In August, Nitish Kumar laid the foundation for Ambuja Concrete North's Rs 1,600-crore cement grinding unit in Nawada district. Besides this subsidiary of theirs, the Adani Group has pledged Rs 5,500 crore across various sectors. Coca-Cola is establishing a Rs 1,235-crore beverage plant in Buxar. JK Lakshmi Cement is launching a Rs 400-crore unit in Madhubani. Three ethanol processing units—collectively valued at over Rs 600 crore—are set to rise in Nalanda, Muzaffarpur and Samastipur. Indeed, in the past two years, Bihar has received Rs 12,000 crore in investment proposals, significantly higher than the Rs 2,500 crore received between 2016 and 2022. Since June alone, industries have expressed interest in proposals amounting to Rs 6,126 crore.

These are not empty proposals. The Bihar Industrial Area Development Authority (BIADA), responsible for acquiring and leasing land, has leased 7,592 acres over the past two years—a sharp rise compared to the 1,550 acres leased between 2016 and 2022. A large portion of these proposals, officials say, are from the textile, leather, food processing and cement industries. In the food processing sec-

of as the place where industry was born in ancient India. But it has been saddled with a modern jinx. Still held back by a cussedly feudal economy, it became the worst performer among all major states in India by the early 1980s, with nothing changing the stark asymmetry between its mineral-rich and industrialised south and riverine, agrarian north. In the next decade, politics of social justice came with a nearly institutionalised form of lawlessness, creating conditions especially hostile for industry. At the end of the 1990s, the state's per capita GSDP fell to a third of the national average. Then, in 2000, came the state's bifurcation, with the industry-rich